Carne Asada

Serves 6 · Marinate 4–8 hrs · Cook 10–12 min · Grill or cast iron

INGREDIENTS

- 1½ lb flank steak (or skirt or flap)
- ½ cup chopped fresh cilantro leaves
- 1/3 cup olive oil
- ¼ cup reduced-sodium soy sauce
- ¼ cup freshly squeezed orange juice
- 2 tbsp freshly squeezed lime juice
- 4 cloves garlic, minced
- 1 jalapeño, seeded and diced
- 1 tsp ground cumin
- 1 tsp freshly ground black pepper, plus more
- Kosher salt, to taste

METHOD

1. Whisk the cilantro, olive oil, soy sauce, orange juice, lime juice, garlic, jalapeño, cumin, and 1 tsp pepper in a medium bowl. **Pull ½ cup out now and refrigerate it** — that reserved portion is the finishing sauce, and it has to be set aside before anything touches raw meat.
2. Put the steak and the remaining marinade in a gallon zip bag or bowl. Chill **4 to 8 hours**, ideally the full 8 overnight, turning occasionally. Do not run past 8 — the orange and lime acid keeps breaking down muscle fiber and the texture goes mushy rather than tender.
3. Preheat the grill to high, about **450°F**, and scrape the grates clean; residue is what makes the steak stick and tear off the crust you're trying to build. Indoors, use a cast iron grill pan or skillet and get it screaming hot — nonstick can't hold enough heat for a real sear.
4. Drain the steak and discard the used marinade. Pat both sides **completely dry** with paper towels; any film of marinade left on the surface boils off as steam and the meat greys instead of charring. Season with salt and pepper.
5. Grill **3–6 minutes per side**, flipping once, to an internal temperature of **125–130°F** for medium-rare. This is a hot-and-fast cut; anything past medium (140°F) turns dry no matter how long it marinated.
6. Rest at least **5 minutes** before cutting so the juices redistribute instead of running out onto the board.
7. Slice thin **against the grain** — perpendicular to the direction of the fibers. This shortens them and is the single biggest factor between tender and chewy. For tacos, cut the slices crosswise into cubes.
8. Serve warm with the reserved ½ cup sauce spooned over, plus tortillas, rice, beans, guacamole.

NOTES

- **Choosing the cut.** Flank is leanest and easiest to find; skirt has more fat and crisps hardest on a hot grill; flap is thicker with looser, more marbled grain. All three take marinade well.
- **Salt goes on last.** Season after draining, right before it hits the heat — the soy sauce already salts the interior during the marinade.
- **Squeeze the citrus.** Bottled juice works in a pinch but the brightness that defines this marinade comes from fresh.
- **Reduced-sodium soy specifically.** A full ¼ cup of standard soy next to this little liquid overwhelms everything; reduced-sodium keeps the umami without the salt spike.
- **Double the sauce.** The marinade portion scales cleanly — make 2× or 3× if you want extra for tacos or burrito bowls.
- **No cilantro?** Flat-leaf parsley is the closest structural swap. Ground coriander (the seed of the same plant) adds related flavor but reads warmer and earthier, not fresh.
- **Make ahead and freeze.** Marinade keeps 1 day in the fridge on its own. Or freeze the steak in its marinade up to 3 months — thaw overnight in the fridge, then cook as written with a few extra minutes.
- **Leftovers.** Airtight, 3–4 days. Reheat covered with foil at 250°F so it warms through without cooking further.
- **Also good on chicken.** The marinade works as-is for pollo asado.

Adapted from Chungah Rhee, Damn Delicious (damndelicious.net/2019/05/05/carne-asada). Method rewritten and condensed for personal kitchen use.